Building empathy for chickens

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Hi I'm Seth

- I work at the Humane and Sustainable Food Lab (HSFL), which is dedicated to accelerating the end of factory farming.
- I write stuff at https://regressiontothemeat.substack.com/.
- I presented at RECAP previously about a meta-analysis (more on that in a minute).

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Small body problem

- Also called the small animal replacement problem.
- Defined on the EA forum as "is the concern that certain diet changes aimed at causing less harm to the world might, in fact, cause more harm - specifically, changes that result from eating smaller animals instead of larger ones"
- It's a problem because it puts the climate movement and the animal activism movement at cross-purposes, e.g. the coolfood pledge from WRI which encourages people to eat more chicken and fish.
- There's a fair bit of philosophical/ethical work about SBP — Maya has written about this — but almost nothing empirical addressing the small body problem directly.

Chickens are numerous and their lives are bad

- Almost all terrestrial farmed animals are chickens – about 70 of 80 billion or so.
- Their lives are especially bad, per Will McAskill (& others): "Of all the animals raised for food, **broiler chickens, layer hens, and pigs are kept in the worst conditions**, by a considerable margin... [On a scale of -10 to 10, economist Bailey] Norwood rates beef cattle at 6 and dairy cows at 4. In contrast, his average rating for broiler chickens is -1, and for pigs and caged hens is -5."

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It's hard to empathize with chickens

We (advocates and vegans) are weird. We look at pictures like this one from The Humane League and say, that's horrible! Most people don't feel the same way. Evolutionary distance matters.



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Context: meaningfully reducing consumption of meat and animal products is hard

- Last year I worked on a meta-analytic review of interventions to get people to eat less MAP.
- As of 12/2023, 35 papers met our criteria (RCTs with > 50 subjects that measured MAP consumption directly at least a day after treatment began), and none focused on chickens specifically.
- No approach consistently produces meaningful effects, all effect sizes small.



Full Length Article

Meaningfully reducing consumption of meat and animal products is an unsolved problem: A meta-analysis

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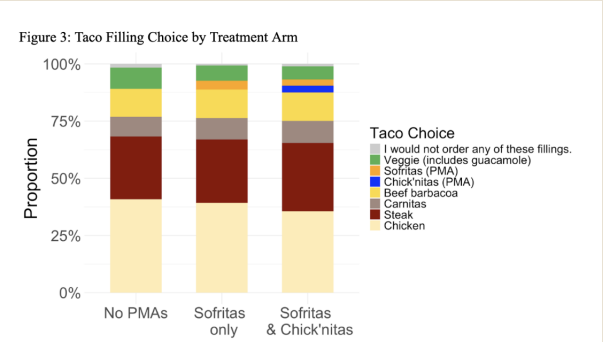
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Chicken analogues on menus?

- My colleague Jessica is going to talk more about this at a future meeting, but spoiler, in a Chipotle-like setting, adding new plant-based options doesn't seem to do much, including a chicken analogue.



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So how are we going to build empathy for chickens?

- I have five ideas, but they're not very good (either not going to be persuasive or not an interesting question).
- I'll briefly describe them, and then I want you to tell me how they can be better :)

But first, what makes a good paper?

- Starts with a good question! That's where I'm stuck.
  - I think I have a research *topic* — chickens — but not a research question (CC Kristin Luker's *Salsa Dancing Into the Social Sciences*).
  - I can narrow it even further to Angrist & Pischke's first FAQ in *Mostly Harmless Econometrics* – "What is the causal relationship of interest?"
    - I don't know what my Y is. I think once we pin that down it won't be too hard to figure out the X. But when it comes to chickens, what's the right estimand?

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Idea 1: Start by talking about animal weights as a way of thinking about SBP

Something like:

- "How big do you think a cow is? How big do you think a chicken is?"
- "Actually the answers are 6 pounds and 1200 pounds. So it takes about 200 times more chickens to produce a given amount of meat as it does cows. . . this called the small body problem"
- "How does that make you feel about eating these animals? Are chicken's numerous deaths morally relevant to your dietary choices?"
- Problem: as a friend put it, "I think both of those animals are in the food chain so it doesn't matter how many of them have to die to feed me"
- I think this will not meaningfully change how anyone eats.

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Idea 2: Explicitly frame the cow/chicken trade-off in trolley problem terms

Ask people:

- "Say you could save the life of a cow or a chicken, but only one. Which would you choose?"
- Then keep pushing forward until you got to a cow-chicken trade off number (e.g. 6 chickens is worth one cow)
- "ACTUALLY COWS ARE HUGE SO DID YOU KNOW THE REAL RATIO IS LIKE 200 TO 1???"

Same problem as before: the number could be 1000 to 1 and it's still OK to eat both. (Also the "global warming is bad" term in the utility function might have a lot more weight than the animal welfare term.)

Idea three: op-ed about the small body problem

- Maya has a *Science* article about the small body problem, and we could write an op-ed or pamphlet adapting it.
- I expect small effects. As a poli sci professor friend put it: "I am certain that attitudes are (a little bit) malleable on this subject, and I bet that an op-ed based on the Mathur Science you linked to would move attitudes, oh, by about 0.15 to 0.20 standard deviations in the short term :)"



Idea 4: get ethical vegetarians to really think about the egg/beef tradeoff

- Ethical vegetarians draw the line at meat, but not eggs, for some set of reasons that boil down to "it feels bad to kill an animal to feed me."
- But actually lots of chickens die in the egg-laying lifecycle, e.g. all the male chicks culled, and inevitably egg-laying hens are slaughtered when they stop laying and turned into dog food.
- A beef cow lives about as long on average as an egg-laying hen and probably produces *more* burgers than an egg-laying hen produces eggs, depending on size and productivity. And again, beef cattle live better lives on average.

Idea 4 continued

- So all in all, you're contributing to just as many animal deaths, and a fair bit more animal suffering, when you buy eggs relative to beef. So why do you do it?
- Goal of the study would be to put people on the spot where they really look inwards and answer this question.

Problem(s): I have no idea how to do this without provoking reactive defenses and I don't see a viable path from this to meaningful behavioral change.

I really do want to know what happens when you confront people with hard moral truths, but I don't see how that helps animals. Could be interesting anyway.

Idea 5: test variants of the BCC for building popular support

- Better [European] Chicken Commitment is actually pretty jargon-y b/c it's aimed at producers.
- But if you wanted to test building popular support, you might try jargon-free language, like so, and see how that that affected support for a hypothetical policy making it mandatory

BCC Tenet (Jargon Arm)	Concrete Translation (Concrete Arm)
Breed: "Uses BCC-approved, higher-welfare breeds."	**Breed:** "Uses healthier, natural-growing breeds that don't suffer from painful leg deformities caused by unnaturally fast growth."
Space: "A maximum stocking density of 6.0 lbs/sq. ft."	**Space:** "Gives each bird enough space to turn around, stretch its wings, and walk, instead of being packed wing-to-wing."
Enrichment: "Provides environmental enrichments (e.g., perches)."	**Enrichment:** "Provides perches for roosting and objects to peck at, allowing chickens to behave like actual chickens."

Idea 5 (problems)

- This is my favorite I've come up with so far, and I think it would work to build that support, but it's not very *interesting.*
- Of course framing things in terms people understand is going to increase support for a policy. But the BCC folks aren't *trying* to get popular support, they're trying to affect producer behavior.
  - What's our theoretical quantity of interest here? Or am I just doing market research for animal advocacy orgs?
- And what's our political lever here? ballots across Europe or California?

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That having been said

- I like the idea of trying to build popular intuition around why fast-growing breeds are bad for chicken welfare.
- A lot of the problems for chickens start there, but it's an abstract, unintuitive problem.
- 'Frankenchicken' is an effort to do this.
- On the other hand,if that's all you change, it's not clear how that affects suffering overall. Could just be that you leave birds living marginally longer lives in hell.

So. . . what should I do?

Some questions:

- Did anything here strike you as likely to change attitudes?
- If not, what would you suggest instead?
- What's the right outcome?
- Imagine a hypothetical budget of $25K, how would *you* spend it to develop a novel idea about how to make people care about chickens?
- Should I not be going for novel? Should I just be testing existing theories of making people care about chickens? If so what are the best theories?